pact of our unique caste system has a pervasive influence on our mindsets, causing us to create hierarchies wherever possible, whether in society or art," says Bhatt, who has straddled every medium and studied and overcome each bias on the way.

The artist studied painting and printmaking at M.S. University in Baroda. In the early 1960s, he won a scholarship to study at the Accademia di Belle Arti in Naples, Italy, and later at the Pratt Institute in New York, where he came across abstract expressionism. He dabbled in cubism initially, which later evolved through pop art imagery and eventually settled into a visual language inspired by traditional folk motifs.

IN HIS GRAPHIC PRINTS, BHATT **INTEGRATED POLITICAL CRITIQUE TO** CHALLENGE INSTITUTIONS OPPOSING PLURALISM AND LIBERAL VALUES

Over the years, printmaking became synonymous with Jyoti Bhatt, so that when he returned to MSU Baroda in 1966, he was armed with a thorough knowledge of the intaglio process. Over his illustrious teaching career at the institute, he prolifically photo-documented its journey, the creative practices of its students and faculty, and Baroda's architecturally important buildings.

"My artworks reflect what I observe. It is a record of the world as I experience it, filtered through a visual language that feels honest to me," he concludes. ■

—Arshia

PAINTING ▼

Colonial Shades

AN EXHIBITION OF **COMPANY PAINTINGS** AT DAG DELHI SHOWS A SUBSTANTIVE DIALOGUE BETWEEN INDIAN AND EUROPEAN ART

The humble custard apple ('*shareefa*' or '*sitaphal*' in Hindi) is cherished across north India for its intense sugary taste and the zing it adds to otherwise straitlaced desserts. But before I saw several 18th-century gouache-on-paper paintings of the fruit, drawn in the style of European botanical drawings, I had never quite realised the geometric elegance of its honeycomb-like form. The works are on display at Delhi's DAG, a part of their ongoing exhibition 'A Treasury of Life: Indian Company Paintings c. 1790-1835' (on till July 5). As the name suggests, these 'Company paintings' (nearly 200 of them, from the 18th and 19th centuries) were drawn by Indian artists commissioned by India-based European patrons.

"In all of the company paintings, there is a substantive dialogue going on between Indian and European art," says Giles Tillotson, senior vice president at DAG and the curator of this exhibition. "Indian artists used the western printed image—mostly British but also French, like the works sourced from Pondicherry here—as a template or a starting point to develop a new, hybrid sensibility." There are examples of this hybridity across the three principal categories the exhibition is divided into—natural history, architecture and Indian customs/rituals. In the natural history category, for instance, the choice of botanical subjects was often driven by the cultural or religious significance of the plant/fruit (like the tulsi plant, a common object of worship for Hindus).

Some of the Indian artists, hitherto used to royal patronage, worked in the dominant style of their erstwhile kingdom. Once they were exposed to, as Tillotson says, "the western printed image", their style naturally accommodated the new influences. 'A Treasury of Life' makes the case for 'Company paintings' to be considered as early examples of (or precursors to) Indian modernism. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha





EARLY COMPANY Above, 'Festival at Thirunallar' (Madras, watercolour, c. 1800); right, 'Kali Puja' (Murshidabad, watercolour, early 1800s)